

"Not so loud, please, Mr. Street, because we are simply trying to keep you from a foolish action. What can you do with the money?"

"None of your business. I want that cash."

"Well, if you insist, let us give you a certified check."

"Cash," repeated Street shrilly, "or I go out and give the story to the newspapers."

They surrendered then and gave him his bundle of thousand-dollar bills. As I received that welcome money from him and gave my hurried assurance it would be quite safe in the City Bank, neither of us had a clairvoyant hint of a future in which his son and my daughter would marry and make us grandfather-partners in a completely adorable little girl; indeed, two adorable little girls.

Madness, of course, is the word for the sudden, unreasonable, overpowering fright that communicates itself through all the human herd at such a time as that to which I refer. From too much usage, the word "panic" has ceased to have its proper cutting-edge as a tool for the mind. It has degenerated into a mere time symbol in our vocabularies, a sort of asterisk, marking the calendar of our memory opposite such years as 1873, 1893, and 1907. Yet, a banking panic, such as occurred in 1907, is actually akin to that which happens when a leaking ship's company is mastered by fear, instead of a stern captain, and rushes for the small boats, forgetful of all obligations except the brutish one of self-preservation. This swift contagion comes, when it does, as quickly as you can say the word: "panic!"

Oh, but we had a stern captain in 1907; it was during those days of strain that I discovered for myself what an admirable intelligence gleamed through the fierce eyes of J. Pierpont Morgan. He was our captain; he was literally the nation's captain. His leadership was something that was taken for granted when the banking mechanism was floundering in difficulties. The most important men responded to his call, eagerly, and usually were quick to do his bidding. Mr. Morgan could be savage when he was out of patience, and, when he was crossed, unrelenting.